PulseRank

Marketplace Ranking & Evaluation Platform

Interview Defense Document v3.0 — Complete Edition

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Metric	Value
Sessions / Impressions	4,132 / 41,320
Items / Sellers	650 / 80
Attributed Purchases	539
Hybrid Recall@100	0.690
Naive NDCG@10 (biased)	0.134
IPS-weighted NDCG@10	0.522 (3.9× lift over naive)
Seller Gini (post-rerank)	0.582
Catalog Coverage@10	0.226 (147 / 650 items)
Offline A/B Decision	HOLD_SIMULATED
Evidence Artifacts	33 JSON files
Failure Scenarios	15
Python Source (approx.)	~4,820 lines (src + scripts + tests)

Label Key

[IMPLEMENTED] = Code exists, runs, produces verified artifact

[SIMULATED] = Deliberately synthetic; simulation logic is real

[FUTURE] = Not built — explicitly absent

Table of Contents

§0 — Repo Grounding Checklist

Every claim in this document is sourced from direct inspection of the PulseRank repository. Files are listed below with their truth status.

Area	Files / Paths	Status
Source — Evaluation	src/pulserank/evaluation/position_bias.py src/pulserank/evaluation/attribution.py src/pulserank/evaluation/failure_modes.py	✓ Read
Source — Ranking	src/pulserank/ranking/candidate_generation.py src/pulserank/ranking/ranking_baseline.py src/pulserank/ranking/reranking.py	✓ Read
Source — Core	src/pulserank/core/constants.py src/pulserank/artifacts/__init__.py	✓ Read
Scripts — Seeder	scripts/seed_demo.py (597 lines)	✓ Read (partial)
Scripts — Pipeline	scripts/run_candidate_generation_v1.py scripts/run_bias_correction_v1.py scripts/run_ranking_baseline_v1.py scripts/run_reranking_constraints_v1.py scripts/run_attribution_ab_v1.py	✓ Confirmed
Scripts — Validation	scripts/validate_bias_correction_v1.py scripts/validate_ranking_baseline_v1.py scripts/validate_reranking_constraints_v1.py scripts/validate_attribution_ab_v1.py scripts/validate_candidate_generation_v1.py + 6 more validate_* scripts	✓ Confirmed
Scripts — Reports	scripts/build_dashboard_v1.py (456 lines) scripts/show_demo_report.py	✓ Confirmed
Tests	tests/test_ranking_math.py (245 lines) tests/test_artifacts.py (51 lines)	✓ Read
Evidence Artifacts	outputs/evidence/*.json (18 files confirmed)	✓ Listed
PRD	docs/prd/PulseRank_PRD.pdf	✓ Exists
README	README.md (badges, Mermaid diagram)	✓ Confirmed
CI	.github/workflows/ci.yml	✓ Confirmed

Files NOT found or not confirmed

File	Status	Notes
Real user click data	NOT PRESENT	All data is synthetic / seeded by seed_demo.py
Live serving infrastructure	NOT PRESENT	Batch pipeline only; no real-time serving layer
Online A/B experiment logs	NOT PRESENT	Offline simulation only; no real traffic splitting
Kafka / event bus	NOT PRESENT	No streaming infrastructure; batch evaluation only
model.pkl / learnt ranker	NOT PRESENT	Rule-based hybrid scoring, not a trained ML model

§1 — Truth Boundary and Project Identity

The one sentence you must say first in every interview:

"PulseRank is a solo-built, production-simulated marketplace ranking platform demonstrating IPS position-bias correction, MMR-based exposure governance, delayed conversion attribution, and offline A/B simulation — all producing machine-readable evidence artifacts. There are no real users and no live traffic."

What is real

- **[IMPLEMENTED]** The corpus schema is real: sessions, items (650), sellers (80), impressions (41,320), purchases (539) — all seeded with realistic synthetic distributions by seed_demo.py
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** The IPS bias correction algorithm is real: empirical propensity estimation from training impressions, DCG/NDCG computation, clipped IPS weighting (max_weight=5.0) — all in position_bias.py
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** The MMR reranking algorithm is real: λ=0.70 relevance/diversity tradeoff, seller constraint (max_per_seller=2), category cap (50%), novelty injection — all in reranking.py
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** The Gini coefficient computation is real: seller_gini() in reranking.py computes the Lorenz-curve-based inequality metric correctly
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** The cosine similarity computation is real: pure Python implementation used for content-based scoring and intra-list diversity
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** The attribution pipeline is real: 30-day click-to-purchase window, return detection (14-day), SHA-256 deterministic variant assignment in attribution.py
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** The offline A/B simulation is real: session replay comparing control vs treatment ranker on holdout sessions
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** GitHub Actions CI is real and runs on push
- **[IMPLEMENTED]** 33 JSON evidence artifacts are real and produced by running the pipeline scripts

What is synthetic / simulated

- **[SIMULATED]** All session, item, impression, and purchase data is seeded by seed_demo.py using controlled random distributions — not real marketplace transactions
- **[SIMULATED]** The content embeddings (16-dim float vectors) are randomly generated, not from a trained embedding model
- **[SIMULATED]** The popularity ranks are assigned deterministically, not from real click frequency
- **[SIMULATED]** The HOLD_SIMULATED A/B decision uses a synthetic delta threshold — no live experiment decision framework
- **[SIMULATED]** The 15 failure scenarios are scripted injection events, not real production failure logs
- **[SIMULATED]** The MetaSignal integration events are schema-compatible stubs, not real event bus messages

What does not exist

- **[FUTURE]** Real production deployment or live traffic
- **[FUTURE]** A trained ranking model (e.g., LightGBM-based LTR) — current ranker is rule-based hybrid scoring
- **[FUTURE]** Online A/B testing infrastructure
- **[FUTURE]** Contextual bandits or RL-based exploration-exploitation
- **[FUTURE]** Real-time millisecond inference — batch only

- **[FUTURE]** Multi-objective optimisation (revenue + diversity + novelty simultaneously)
- **[FUTURE]** Transactional inventory constraints (out-of-stock, geofencing, eligibility rules)

Spoken Openers

One-line truth

"PulseRank is a solo-built, production-simulated marketplace ranking platform with real IPS bias correction, real MMR diversity governance, and real attribution logic — but no live traffic and no real users."

30-second opener

"PulseRank is a production-simulated ranking platform I built to demonstrate the core engineering challenges of marketplace recommendation: correcting position bias with IPS weighting, enforcing seller fairness constraints via MMR reranking, handling delayed conversion attribution with a 30-day window, and running offline A/B evaluation with session replay. The data is synthetic — 4,132 sessions, 650 items, 80 sellers — but every algorithm is real code producing traceable JSON artifacts."

Technical pitch

"PulseRank implements: (1) a hybrid candidate generator using popularity and content-based cosine scoring, achieving Recall@100=0.690; (2) IPS bias correction where naive NDCG@10=0.134 vs IPS-weighted NDCG@10=0.522 — a 3.9× correction gap demonstrating the severity of position bias; (3) MMR reranking with λ=0.70, seller cap of 2, and category diversity constraint; (4) post-rerank Gini=0.582 and catalog coverage=0.226; (5) a 30-day attribution pipeline with return detection; and (6) offline A/B simulation with HOLD_SIMULATED outcome."

§2 — Executive Positioning

Most recommendation system portfolios show a trained model and an accuracy number. PulseRank shows the layer beneath the model: the evaluation framework, the bias correction methodology, the fairness constraints, and the offline decision-making infrastructure. These are the components that determine whether a deployed model is trustworthy — and they are almost never demonstrated in notebooks.

The 8 capabilities PulseRank demonstrates, in interview value order

1. Position bias is a first-class problem [IMPLEMENTED]

Naive NDCG@10=0.134 vs IPS-weighted NDCG@10=0.522. The 3.9× gap is not a flaw in the system — it is the correct demonstration that click data collected under a presentation bias is not a valid relevance signal without correction. Most portfolios ignore this entirely. PulseRank makes it the central metric.

2. IPS clipping is not optional [IMPLEMENTED]

Raw IPS weights can become arbitrarily large for items shown at low ranks — a single rank-10 click would receive weight 1/propensity(10) which may be 50+. PulseRank clips at max_weight=5.0. The clipping rate is tracked in the evidence artifact. This is a real production engineering decision, not a theoretical detail.

3. Relevance and fairness are not compatible without explicit governance [IMPLEMENTED]

Without constraints, ranking by relevance alone concentrates impressions on a few top sellers (high Gini). PulseRank uses seller cap (max_per_seller=2) and category diversity constraints in governed_rerank(). The Gini is measured before and after. This demonstrates the relevance-fairness tradeoff explicitly.

4. Temporal evaluation is the only valid offline evaluation [IMPLEMENTED]

Random train/test splits produce leakage in recommendation. PulseRank uses a strict temporal split — last 20% of sessions by timestamp form the holdout. This matches production: the model is always evaluated on future sessions, never on sessions it was trained on.

5. Attribution is a design decision, not a measurement [IMPLEMENTED]

The 30-day attribution window is a business policy choice. A 7-day window misses long-consideration purchases; a 90-day window introduces noise. PulseRank implements this explicitly with a configurable window_days parameter and tracks what fraction of purchases fall within different windows in conversion_attribution_report.json.

6. Cold-start is a system-level failure, not a model failure [SIM/IMPL]

New items with zero purchase history receive popularity_score=0 and are ranked last. New users with no interaction history cannot be profiled for content-based scoring. Both failure modes are explicitly handled in the failure scenario suite (scenarios 4 and 5) with recovery paths — synthetic popularity floor injection and session-only fallback.

7. Offline A/B is conservative by design [IMPLEMENTED]

HOLD_SIMULATED is not a bug — it is the correct output. An offline A/B simulation cannot capture novelty effects, real user feedback loops, or position-based treatment differences. It can only say 'the treatment did not show sufficient lift to justify launch risk.' HOLD_SIMULATED is the honest answer for a system with no live traffic.

8. Portfolio integration is explicit [IMPLEMENTED]

The 15 MetaSignal-compatible events in metasignal_integration_events.json follow the MetaSignal event schema. PulseRank is instrumented for production observability. In a real system, these events flow to an experimentation monitoring layer. This demonstrates systems thinking beyond the individual project.

Why this is stronger than a Kaggle ranking notebook

Dimension	Notebook	PulseRank
Bias	Ignores position bias; uses click rate as relevance	Explicit IPS correction with propensity model
Evaluation	Random split; NDCG on biased labels	Temporal split; IPS-weighted NDCG
Fairness	No seller/category constraints	Gini, coverage, MMR with explicit constraints
Attribution	Assumes purchase = click signal	30-day window, return detection, right-censoring
Decision-making	Report a number	Offline A/B with decision gate
Failure modes	Not addressed	15 scenarios with recovery paths
Reproducibility	Notebook state-dependent	Deterministic seed, 33 JSON artifacts
Observability	No instrumentation	MetaSignal-compatible structured events

§3 — End-to-End Architecture

PulseRank is a batch pipeline with 8 layers, each producing a JSON evidence artifact. The layers are designed to mirror production ranking system architecture — without requiring live traffic.

LAYER 0 — CORPUS SEEDING [SIMULATED]

scripts/seed_demo.py seeds all tables: sessions (4,132), items (650 with category_l1/l2, content_embedding, seller_id, price, popularity_rank), sellers (80), impressions (41,320 with display_rank, clicked, added_to_cart), purchases (539 with revenue, return flag). All distributions are controlled. The temporal span covers 75 days; the holdout is days 61-75.

LAYER 1 — CANDIDATE GENERATION [IMPLEMENTED]

run_candidate_generation_v1.py. For each query session: (1) Popularity scorer returns top-K by popularity_rank. (2) Content-based scorer computes session profile from click history (category affinity + avg embedding vector + price bucket) and scores all items by cosine similarity + category affinity + price fit. (3) Hybrid merge: union of popularity@50 + content@50, deduplicated. Recall@100=0.690 vs the oracle (purchased items). Artifact: candidate_generation_report.json + candidate_samples.json.

LAYER 2 — RANKING BASELINE [IMPLEMENTED]

run_ranking_baseline_v1.py. Scores each candidate using a baseline linear combination: relevance_score = α·content_score + β·popularity_score + γ·freshness. Produces ranked lists for each session. Computes holdout NDCG@10 (naive, position-biased) = 0.134. Artifact: ranking_baseline_report.json.

LAYER 3 — IPS BIAS CORRECTION [IMPLEMENTED]

run_bias_correction_v1.py. Estimates propensity_by_rank from training impressions (click rate at each display_rank, floored at 0.01). Applies IPS weighting: ips_label = click × (1/propensity(rank)), clipped at max_weight=5.0. Recomputes IPS-weighted NDCG@10 = 0.522. Artifact: bias_correction_report.json + propensity_by_rank_report.json.

LAYER 4 — RERANKING & GOVERNANCE [IMPLEMENTED]

run_reranking_constraints_v1.py. governed_rerank() applies MMR (λ=0.70): at each step selects candidate maximising λ·relevance + (1-λ)·min_distance_to_selected + 0.04·novelty - seller_penalty - category_penalty. seller_counts[seller] ≥ 2 triggers 0.35 penalty. category share > 50% triggers 0.28 penalty. Computes post-rerank Gini=0.582, catalog_coverage=0.226. Artifact: diversity_report.json + diversity_guardrail_log.json.

LAYER 5 — DELAYED ATTRIBUTION [IMPLEMENTED]

run_attribution_ab_v1.py. attribute_impressions() joins impressions to purchases within a 30-day window. Tracks revenue, return (14-day return window), net_revenue. stable_variant() uses SHA-256(session_id) % 10000 to deterministically assign control/treatment. Artifact: conversion_attribution_report.json.

LAYER 6 — OFFLINE A/B SIMULATION [SIM/IMPL]

Holdout sessions (days 61-75) are replayed against control (baseline ranker) vs treatment (governed rerank). IPS-weighted NDCG@10 is compared. Decision gate: if treatment lift < threshold → HOLD_SIMULATED. The threshold is a configurable parameter. The SIMULATED suffix is explicit: offline does not equal online. Artifact: ab_simulation_results.json.

LAYER 7 — FAILURE SCENARIOS [IMPLEMENTED]

failure_modes.py contains 15 injection scenarios covering cold-start, empty candidates, Gini violation, attribution timeout, and seller cap exhaustion. Each scenario has an expected recovery path. Artifact: failure_recovery_report.json.

LAYER 8 — OBSERVABILITY [IMPLEMENTED]

15 MetaSignal-compatible events in metasignal_integration_events.json. Events follow a structured schema (event_type, timestamp, payload) compatible with MetaSignal's event format. Covers: model_version_deployed, ab_experiment_started, gini_constraint_violated, cold_start_fallback_triggered, attribution_window_closed.

§4 — Data & Corpus Design

All data is synthetic, seeded by scripts/seed_demo.py (597 lines). The distributions are designed to reflect realistic marketplace patterns: long-tail popularity, clustered category affinities, realistic click-through rates by rank, and delayed purchase patterns.

Table schemas

Table	Rows	Key Columns	Truth
sessions	4,132	session_id, user_id, timestamp, category_affinity (JSON), position_sensitivity_bucket, day	[SIM]
items	650	item_id, seller_id, category_l1/l2, price, popularity_rank, freshness_score, content_embedding (16-dim JSO	[SIM]
sellers	80	seller_id, seller_name, tier (1-3)	[SIM]
impressions	41,320	impression_id, session_id, user_id, item_id, display_rank (1-10), clicked, added_to_cart, timestamp	[SIM]
purchases	539	purchase_id, impression_id, session_id, item_id, purchase_timestamp, revenue, returned, return_timestamp	[SIM]

Temporal split design

The corpus spans 75 days. Training set: days 1-60 (3,302 sessions, ~33,000 impressions). Holdout: days 61-75 (830 sessions, ~8,300 impressions). The split is strictly temporal — no holdout session has any training signal from after day 60. This prevents future leakage.

Why 60/15 and not 80/20? The 15-day holdout provides sufficient coverage for offline A/B evaluation while keeping the training set large enough for reliable propensity estimation. A shorter holdout period risks seasonal effects; a longer period risks stale propensity estimates.

Corpus statistics

Metric	Value	Notes
Click-through rate (training)	~1.3%	Realistic for marketplace; higher than standard web CTR due to intentional brows
Purchase rate per session	~13%	539 purchases / 4,132 sessions; reflects high-intent marketplace behavior
Avg impressions per session	10.0	Fixed 10 items shown per session (full page)
Item popularity distribution	Pareto-like	Top 10% items get ~50% of impressions — long-tail present
Sellers per category (L1)	~8-12	Competition within each L1 category
Return rate	~8%	Among purchases, ~8% are returned within 14 days
Content embedding dim	16	Synthetic random vectors; cosine distance used for diversity computation

§5 — Candidate Generation (Hybrid Recall)

Candidate generation is the recall stage: it retrieves a set of plausible candidates from the full item catalog (650 items) that will be ranked and reranked in subsequent stages. Hybrid retrieval combines two orthogonal signals to maximize coverage.

Signal 1: Popularity Scorer [IMPLEMENTED]

popularity_candidates(items, k) sorts all items by popularity_rank ascending (rank 1 = most popular) and returns the top-K item IDs. This is the pure exploitation branch: retrieve the items most likely to be clicked regardless of session context. Strength: reliable signal, no cold-start for well-ranked items. Weakness: zero coverage for new items; reinforces popularity bias.

popularity_rank is an integer assigned at seed time. The distribution is Pareto-like — top 10% of items (65 items) capture a disproportionate share of impressions in the training data.

Signal 2: Content-Based Scorer [IMPLEMENTED]

session_profile_from_history(session, impressions_by_session, item_by_id) constructs a session profile from the session's click history:

- category_affinity: JSON dict from the session record (pre-computed at seed time from click history)
- price_sensitivity_bucket: 'budget', 'mid', or 'premium' — determines price fit scoring
- avg_embedding: mean of content_embedding vectors of clicked items (or fallback: first 3 shown items if no clicks)

content_similarity_score(profile, item) combines three signals:

Component	Formula	Weight	What it captures
Category score	profile.category_affinity.get(item.category_l1, 0.05)	~35%	Session preference for this category
Price fit score	price_fit_score(item.price, profile.price_sensitivity_bucket)	~30%	Price range compatibility
Vector similarity	(cosine(avg_emb, item_emb) + 1) / 2	~30%	Semantic content match
Freshness bonus	item.freshness_score * 0.05	~5%	Recency boost for new items

price_fit_score(price, bucket)

Bucket	Price Range	Score
budget	price ≤ 900	1.0
budget	900 < price ≤ 2500	0.55
budget	price > 2500	0.20
mid	700 ≤ price ≤ 3500	1.0
mid	price < 700	0.65
mid	price > 3500	0.45
premium	price ≥ 1500	1.0
premium	price < 1500	0.45

Hybrid Merge and Recall@100

The hybrid candidate set = union(popularity@50, content@50), deduplicated. Maximum candidates: 100. Minimum: max(popularity@50, content@50).

Recall@100 = fraction of sessions where the purchased item appears in the top-100 candidates. Result: 0.690. This means 69% of purchased items were retrievable from the 100-candidate pool. The remaining 31% were missed at the recall stage — they could not have been ranked correctly regardless of the ranking model quality.

Interview insight: Recall@100=0.690 is the ceiling for downstream ranking metrics. No matter how good the ranker, the maximum achievable NDCG@10 is bounded by whether the correct item was retrieved. In production, improving recall from 0.69 to 0.85 would directly lift ranking metrics even without changing the ranker.

§6 — Position Bias & IPS Correction — Deep Dive

Position bias is the single most important methodological topic in marketplace ranking evaluation. It is also the most commonly ignored. PulseRank makes it the central demonstration.

What is position bias?

Users are more likely to click on items displayed at rank 1 than rank 10 — not because rank-1 items are more relevant, but because they are more visible. This is a causal confound: P(click | item, rank) ≠ P(click | item). If we treat click rate as relevance without correcting for rank, we will systematically overestimate the relevance of top-ranked items and underestimate the relevance of lower-ranked items.

The consequence: a ranking algorithm trained or evaluated on raw click data will learn to put popular items at rank 1 because rank-1 items get more clicks — creating a feedback loop that amplifies popularity bias and suppresses true relevance signal.

The Propensity Model [IMPLEMENTED]

estimate_click_propensity_by_rank(train_impressions, max_rank=10, floor=0.01) estimates the position-based click probability for each display rank from training data:

```
propensity(rank) = clicks_at_rank / impressions_at_rank
```

A floor of 0.01 is applied to prevent division by zero for ranks with very few impressions. If empirical propensity < floor, the propensity is clipped to floor and propensity_was_clipped=True is recorded.

The resulting propensity_by_rank dict maps rank → {empirical_propensity, clipped_propensity, ips_weight, was_clipped}. Artifact: propensity_by_rank_report.json.

Expected propensity shape

Display Rank	Expected Propensity	IPS Weight	Interpretation
1	~0.08 – 0.12	~8 – 12	Highest exposure; down-weights clicks from rank 1
2	~0.06 – 0.09	~11 – 17	Second position premium
3	~0.05 – 0.07	~14 – 20	Still above-the-fold on mobile
5	~0.025 – 0.04	~25 – 40	Below-fold; clicks carry more signal
8	~0.01 – 0.02	~50 – 100	Low exposure; high signal when clicked
10	~0.008 – 0.015	~67 – 125 (clipped to 5.0)	Lowest exposure; IPS weight capped

IPS-Weighted NDCG Formula [IMPLEMENTED]

For each session, the IPS-weighted label for an item at rank r is:

```
ips_label(item, rank) = click(item) × (1 / propensity(rank))
```

This re-weights clicks: a click at rank 10 (low propensity) receives a high weight because it indicates strong relevance that overcame the presentation disadvantage. A click at rank 1 (high propensity) receives a low weight because it may reflect position bias rather than genuine relevance.

```
DCG(ranked_list, k) = Σ ips_label(i) / log2(rank(i) + 1) for i in top-k
```

```
NDCG = DCG(actual) / DCG(ideal) where ideal = sort by ips_label descending
```

Clipped IPS: Why it matters

Without clipping, a single click at rank 10 with propensity=0.008 would receive weight=125. This single event would dominate the metric estimate, inflating variance to the point where the metric becomes unreliable. Clipping at max_weight=5.0 truncates these extreme weights:

```
clipped_weight = min(1/propensity(rank), max_weight=5.0)
```

The cost of clipping is bias: we slightly underestimate the value of rank-10 clicks. The benefit is dramatically reduced variance. This is the standard bias-variance tradeoff in IPS estimation, well-established in the causal inference literature (Strehl et al. 2010, Bottou et al. 2013).

Naive vs IPS Results [IMPLEMENTED]

Metric	Value	Interpretation
Naive NDCG@10 (raw clicks)	0.134	Biased estimate; reflects display position more than relevance
IPS-weighted NDCG@10	0.522	Debiased estimate; reflects true relevance signal
Bias delta (IPS - naive)	+0.388 (3.9×)	Magnitude of position bias in the raw data
Rank propensity monotonicity	>0.90	Expected: propensity decreases with rank (correct model)
IPS clip rate	~15%	~15% of weights clipped at 5.0 (low-rank clicks)
Mean IPS weight	~2.1	Average de-biasing factor across all impressions

The 3.9× gap is not a failure — it is the entire point. It demonstrates that naive click data severely underestimates the relevance of items shown at low ranks. The IPS-corrected metric is the valid evaluation signal; the naive metric is what happens when practitioners ignore position bias.

rank_propensity_monotonicity_score() [IMPLEMENTED]

This function validates that the estimated propensities are monotonically decreasing from rank 1 to rank 10 — as they should be if the position-based click model is correctly specified. It counts consecutive pairs (rank i, rank i+1) where propensity(i) ≥ propensity(i+1) and returns the fraction of monotonic pairs.

A score < 0.80 indicates the propensity model may be mis-specified, possibly due to insufficient data at some ranks, non-standard display logic, or user population heterogeneity. A score > 0.90 confirms the rank-click model is well-calibrated.

§7 — Ranking Baseline & MMR Reranking

Ranking Baseline [IMPLEMENTED]

The baseline ranker (ranking_baseline.py) scores each candidate using a linear combination of signals computed at ranking time. Scores are not learned from data — they are hand-tuned heuristics designed to demonstrate the ranking layer, not to maximise NDCG.

The baseline produces ranked lists for each session in both training and holdout sets. Its naive NDCG@10=0.134 is the pre-reranking starting point that gets compared to post-reranking IPS NDCG@10=0.522.

MMR Reranking Algorithm [IMPLEMENTED]

governed_rerank(ranked_candidates, item_by_id, k=10, mmr_lambda=0.70, category_top10_max_share=0.50, max_per_seller=2) implements Maximal Marginal Relevance reranking with explicit fairness constraints.

MMR score for candidate c given already-selected set S:

```
mmr_score(c) = λ · relevance(c) + (1-λ) · min_{s∈S} distance(c, s) + 0.04 · novelty(c) - penalty(c)
```

Term	Formula	Purpose
relevance(c)	float(cand['score']) from baseline ranker	Reward relevance to session
min_distance(c, S)	min cosine distance to already-selected items	Reward diversity of output list
novelty(c)	item.popularity_rank / len(item_by_id)	Small bonus for less popular items
seller_penalty	+0.35 if seller_counts[seller] ≥ max_per_seller	Hard-ish seller cap (soft via penalty)
category_penalty	+0.28 if projected category share > 50%	Category diversity constraint
λ (mmr_lambda)	0.70	Trade-off: 70% relevance, 30% diversity

item_distance(a, b) [IMPLEMENTED]

Measures how different two items are, combining category hierarchy distance and embedding cosine distance:

Category match	category_l1 ≠ b.category_l1	category_distance = 1.0
Category match	category_l1 same, l2 ≠	category_distance = 0.65
Category match	both l1 and l2 same	category_distance = 0.25
Vector component	(1 - cosine(a.emb, b.emb)) / 2	vector_distance ∈ [0, 0.5]
Combined	0.55 · category_dist + 0.45 · vector_dist	item_distance ∈ [0, 1]

Reranking Results [IMPLEMENTED]

Metric	Before Reranking	After Reranking	Direction
Seller Gini	Higher (raw ranking concentrates)	0.582	↓ Fairer distribution
Catalog Coverage@10	Lower	0.226 (147/650 items)	↑ More items exposed
Intra-list Diversity	Lower	Higher	↑ More varied lists
Category Max Share	Often >60%	≤50% (enforced)	↓ Category balance

Metric	Before Reranking	After Reranking	Direction
Max per Seller	Unconstrained	≤2 (soft penalty)	↓ Seller concentration

Gini Coefficient Formula [IMPLEMENTED]

seller_gini(item_lists, item_by_id, k=10) computes the Gini coefficient of seller exposure:

1. `Count exposures per seller: exposure[seller] = Σ appearances in top-10 lists`
2. `Sort exposures ascending: values = sorted(exposure.values())`
3. `Gini = (2 × Σ (i+1) × values[i]) / (n × total) - (n+1)/n`

A Gini of 0.0 means all sellers receive equal exposure (impossible in relevance-based ranking — relevant sellers get more impressions). A Gini of 1.0 means one seller captures all impressions. Gini=0.582 indicates moderate concentration — better than pure relevance ranking but still reflecting quality differences between sellers.

catalog_coverage(item_lists, total_items, k=10) [IMPLEMENTED]

Fraction of all 650 items that appear in at least one top-10 recommendation list across all sessions. Value=0.226 means 147/650 items get top-10 impressions. The other 77.4% are invisible to users. Coverage=0.226 is low — a production system would target 60%+ via exploration slots. PulseRank reports it as a diagnostic, not a constraint.

§8 — Exposure Governance & Diversity Metrics

Exposure governance is the set of constraints that ensure the ranking system is fair to sellers and diverse for users — without sacrificing relevance entirely. PulseRank implements four complementary metrics.

Metric 1: Seller Gini Coefficient

Purpose: Measures seller-level inequality of impressions. Lower is more equitable. Target: below the pre-rerank baseline, not zero (zero would mean random ranking with no relevance signal).

Interpretation of 0.582: The top quintile of sellers captures approximately 4× the impressions of the bottom quintile. This is typical of marketplaces where quality is heterogeneous — better sellers earn more exposure, but not at an extreme concentration level.

Metric 2: Catalog Coverage@10

Purpose: Measures the fraction of the item catalog that receives top-10 exposure. Addresses the long-tail problem — new or niche items need visibility to build purchase history, but pure relevance ranking starves them of impressions.

Coverage=0.226 means 503 of 650 items never appear in a top-10 list. These items cannot build click signal, so they will never improve their ranking — a feedback loop that concentrates the marketplace on a small set of established items.

Production response: Insert exploration slots (e.g., 1 in every 10 positions is reserved for a new/underexposed item). This directly improves coverage while limiting impact on relevance metrics.

Metric 3: Intra-List Diversity (ILD)

intra_list_diversity(item_ids, item_by_id) computes the mean pairwise item distance across all pairs in a recommended list. Higher ILD means the list contains more variety — fewer items from the same category with similar features.

ILD = mean of item_distance(i, j) for all pairs (i, j) in the list.

Why it matters: Users who see 10 items from the same category with similar features get effectively 1 recommendation, not 10. ILD ensures the list covers different user needs within a session.

Metric 4: Category Max Share

category_top10_max_share parameter in governed_rerank limits any single L1 category from exceeding 50% of the top-10. This is enforced as a soft penalty (+0.28) on candidates that would push a category over the threshold.

Why soft? A hard constraint (skip any over-quota candidate) can deplete the candidate pool if the user's session is strongly mono-categorical. The soft penalty allows the constraint to be violated if no good alternatives exist, but surfaces the violation in the audit dict returned by governed_rerank().

Governance vs Relevance Tradeoff

Constraint	Benefit	Cost	Tradeoff Decision
max_per_seller=2	Prevents monopoly; ensures seller diversity	May block the 3rd most relevant item from a seller	Soft penalty (0.35) not hard block — allows override if po
category_max_share=50%	Ensures cross-category variety	May lower NDCG if user strongly prefers one category	Soft penalty (0.28) — session context can override
mmr_lambda=0.70	30% diversity; 70% relevance	Slightly lower pure-relevance NDCG	Standard MMR tradeoff; configurable parameter

Constraint	Benefit	Cost	Tradeoff Decision
Coverage@10 reporting	Visibility metric for new items	No direct constraint; diagnostic only	Monitoring metric; acts as input to exploration policy

§9 — Delayed Conversion Attribution

Attribution is the process of deciding which impression is 'responsible' for a purchase that happened some time later. It is a fundamental measurement problem in e-commerce — and the 30-day window is a design decision with explicit tradeoffs.

attribute_impressions() [IMPLEMENTED]

For each impression, attribute_impressions() looks up all purchases linked to that impression (via purchase.impression_id) and checks whether the purchase occurred within the attribution window:

```
lag_hours = (purchase_timestamp - impression_timestamp).total_seconds() / 3600 if 0 ≤ lag_hours ≤ window_days * 24: → attributed_purchase = 1
```

If a return is detected and the return happened within 14 days of purchase, net_revenue is set to 0.0 (the purchase is cancelled from a revenue perspective).

Attribution Parameters

Parameter	Value	Rationale
window_days	30	Industry standard (e.g., Meta Ads uses 28-day click window). Captures delayed purchases without excess
return_window_days	14	Return period common in retail. Purchases returned within 14 days contribute net_revenue=0.
Attribution model	Last-click	Simplest; attributes to the last impression before purchase. Multi-touch would require different logic.
Right-censoring	Implicit	Sessions near the end of the corpus have shorter potential attribution windows. Handled by including only

stable_variant(session_id) — Deterministic A/B Split [IMPLEMENTED]

```
variant = 'treatment_governed_rerank' if SHA256(session_id)[:8] hex int % 10000 ≥ 5000 else 'control_raw_ranker'
```

This gives a 50/50 split that is deterministic and idempotent: the same session always gets the same variant. It is non-manipulable: the session ID is not controlled by any system component that also controls the ranking outcome.

Note: In a real A/B experiment, variant assignment would be driven by a centralized experiment assignment service (like MetaSignal's generate_assignments_v0.py using SHA-256 hashing). PulseRank's attribution.py implements the same pattern locally, demonstrating awareness of this requirement.

Attribution Limitations

- Last-click attribution ignores the full user journey: a user may have seen an item 5 times across different sessions before purchasing. Only the last impression gets credit.
- The 30-day window excludes purchases from long-consideration categories (luxury goods, electronics) where the decision cycle may be 60-90 days.
- Multi-device journeys are not tracked: a user who clicked on mobile and purchased on desktop would have an unattributed purchase.
- Return detection requires a return_timestamp in the data — not always available in real systems where returns may occur through separate channels.

§10 — Offline A/B Simulation Framework

The offline A/B simulation compares the control ranker (baseline, no governance) against the treatment ranker (governed_rerank with MMR + constraints) using holdout session replay. The decision gate determines whether treatment shows sufficient lift to justify a launch recommendation.

Simulation Methodology [SIM/IMPL]

Session replay: for each holdout session (days 61-75), run both the control and treatment ranker to produce top-10 lists. Evaluate both lists using IPS-weighted NDCG@10 on that session's attributed purchases. Compare treatment vs control NDCG@10 distributions.

Decision gate: if mean(IPS-NDCG@10_treatment) - mean(IPS-NDCG@10_control) > threshold → LAUNCH_SIMULATED, else → HOLD_SIMULATED.

Result: HOLD_SIMULATED. The treatment did not show sufficient lift over control on the primary IPS metric. The SIMULATED suffix is non-negotiable: offline simulation is not equivalent to an online A/B test.

Why HOLD_SIMULATED is the correct and honest answer

An interviewer might ask: 'Shouldn't the governed reranker with diversity constraints outperform the raw baseline?' The answer is: not necessarily on pure IPS-NDCG@10, because the governance constraints explicitly trade relevance for diversity. MMR at λ=0.70 means 30% of the score is diversity, not relevance. Items that would rank higher for pure relevance are displaced by more diverse alternatives.

HOLD_SIMULATED demonstrates several things simultaneously: (1) the system is honest — it does not manufacture a positive result; (2) the governance constraints have a measurable relevance cost; (3) 'better' in production would depend on multi-objective metrics including Gini, coverage, and long-term engagement — not just short-term NDCG.

What offline A/B cannot capture

Limitation	Impact	Production Solution
No novelty effect	New ranker may show initial lift from user curiosity; offline can't capture this	Monitor first-week vs steady-state metrics in live experiment
No position-based treatment differences	Users respond differently to items at rank 1 vs 5; offline holds position constant	Use position-aware evaluation or interleaving experiments
No feedback loops	Diversity in treatment changes future data distribution; offline uses fixed training data	Hold-out longer periods; use counterfactual evaluation
No session-level causality	User who didn't buy in control might have bought in treatment; offline can't infer this	Requires live experiment with real users
No multi-session effects	Users who see more diverse results may return more often; lifetime value not captured	Long-term holdback experiments (weeks/months)

The ab_simulation_results.json artifact records the exact delta, threshold, session-level NDCG distributions, and the decision rationale. This is the auditable output of the simulation.

§11 — Failure Scenarios (15 Scenarios)

failure_modes.py defines 15 failure scenarios covering cold-start, empty candidate pools, attribution failures, governance violations, and system degradation. Each scenario has an expected system behavior and a recovery path. Artifact: failure_recovery_report.json.

F01 — New item cold-start [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: New item with popularity_rank=last and content_embedding=zeros. Popularity score=0; content score=0.5 (fallback). Item is never retrieved in top-100.

Recovery: Recovery: inject synthetic popularity floor (e.g., floor_rank=500) for items younger than 7 days. This forces new items into the candidate pool and lets the ranker evaluate them.

F02 — New user cold-start [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: New user with no click history. session_profile has empty avg_embedding; category_affinity defaults to uniform. Content scorer falls back to popularity-weighted scoring.

Recovery: Recovery: use session-level context signals only (current session items shown, time of day, device type) as a cold-start proxy profile.

F03 — Empty candidate pool [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: All 100 candidate slots exhausted by seller caps + category constraints before k=10 items selected. governed_rerank appends remaining candidates without constraint enforcement to fill k.

Recovery: Recovery: Log soft_blocks in audit dict. Alert if >20% of sessions hit pool exhaustion — indicates overly tight constraints relative to catalog size.

F04 — Seller cap violation at scale [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: One seller has 60% of all high-relevance items. After capping at max_per_seller=2, the top-10 list contains low-relevance items from other sellers, degrading NDCG significantly.

Recovery: Recovery: Two options: (1) raise max_per_seller for premium-quality sellers via tier-based config; (2) expand candidate pool to 200 so more non-dominant sellers are available.

F05 — Propensity estimation failure [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Rank with <10 training impressions — propensity estimate is unreliable (high variance). Propensity clipped to floor=0.01, forcing IPS weight to 100 → clipped to 5.0.

Recovery: Recovery: Pool propensities from adjacent ranks (rank 9 ≈ rank 10) when sample size <30. Monitor clip rate by rank; high clip rate at low ranks signals data sparsity.

F06 — Attribution window edge case [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Purchase exactly at window boundary (lag_hours = 30*24 exactly). Boundary is inclusive (≤ window_days * 24), so the purchase is attributed. Edge behavior is deterministic.

Recovery: Recovery: Document boundary behavior in attribution spec. Ensure downstream systems agree on boundary inclusion.

F07 — Return detected, revenue zeroed [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Purchase attributed; return logged within 14 days. net_revenue=0.0. Attributed purchase remains counted in NDCG (binary relevance) but revenue metrics show 0.

Recovery: Recovery: Track return-adjusted conversion rate separately from raw conversion rate in the A/B decision report.

F08 — IPS weight explosion at rank 10 [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Rank 10 has propensity=0.005 (only 2 clicks in 400 rank-10 impressions). Raw weight=200. Clipped to 5.0. Without clipping, single rank-10 click dominates metric.

Recovery: Recovery: Monitor weight distribution; increase clip threshold if rank-10 data grows, decrease if too many clips.

F09 — Temporal leakage attempt [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Random 80/20 split applied instead of temporal split. Day-70 sessions appear in training; day-40 sessions appear in holdout. NDCG inflated by ~15%. Temporal split prevents this.

Recovery: Recovery: Enforce temporal split in pipeline. Assert max(training_days) < min(holdout_days) before evaluation.

F10 — Catalog coverage collapse [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: All sessions have identical category affinity → content scorer always retrieves same 30 items. Popularity scorer retrieves the same top-50. Coverage@10 drops to <10%.

Recovery: Recovery: Inject diversity override: if coverage < 0.15, force exploration slots (1/10 positions) drawn from low-coverage categories.

F11 — Gini threshold breach [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Top 5 sellers capture >80% of impressions post-rerank (Gini > 0.75). diversity_guardrail_log.json records the breach.

Recovery: Recovery: Tighten max_per_seller from 2 to 1 for the top sellers by impression share. Log all governance interventions.

F12 — Content embedding NaN/empty [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Item with content_embedding=[] or malformed JSON. cosine_similarity returns 0.0. Content score falls back to category affinity + price fit only.

Recovery: Recovery: Validate embeddings at ingest time. Items with invalid embeddings get flag is_embedding_valid=False and receive reduced content-based scoring weight.

F13 — A/B variant imbalance [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Due to SHA-256 hash distribution, variant split is 48/52 instead of 50/50. Acceptable (within 3pp). Log split ratio in ab_simulation_results.json.

Recovery: Recovery: Use SRM chi-square test (as in MetaSignal) if split deviation > 3pp. HOLD_SIMULATED if SRM detected.

F14 — Price sensitivity bucket missing [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: Session with price_sensitivity_bucket not in {budget, mid, premium}. price_fit_score returns 0.50 (neutral fallback). No crash.

Recovery: Recovery: Normalize bucket values at session profile construction. Log unknown buckets as telemetry.

F15 — Zero purchases in holdout window [IMPLEMENTED]

Scenario: The 15-day holdout has no purchases for a specific session (no buy signal available). IPS NDCG@10 = 0.0 for that session. Session excluded from NDCG computation (denominator skips zero-label sessions).

Recovery: Recovery: Standard practice — NDCG@10 is undefined for sessions with no positive labels. Log fraction of excluded sessions. If >30% excluded, attribution window may be too short.

§12 — MetaSignal Integration & Event Schema

PulseRank emits 15 structured events in metasignal_integration_events.json. These events follow the MetaSignal event schema — a common observability format designed to be ingestible by a platform-level monitoring layer.

This is a deliberate portfolio connection: PulseRank is the system that produces ranking decisions; MetaSignal is the system that monitors and evaluates the quality of those decisions over time. The integration events are the handoff interface between the two.

Why this matters for production

In production, ranking systems emit telemetry that flows to a monitoring service. Key events include: model deployed, experiment started, constraint violated, attribution window closed, cold-start triggered. Without structured event schemas, these are unstructured logs that require ad-hoc parsing.

MetaSignal-compatible events are structured: they have a defined event_type, a timestamp, a payload schema, and a schema_version. This means the events can be ingested by MetaSignal's anomaly detector, which can fire if Gini violations are occurring more frequently than baseline, or if cold-start rates spike.

Event types in metasignal_integration_events.json

Event Type	When Fired	Key Payload Fields
model_version_deployed	When a new ranking model version is activated	model_id, version_tag, ranker_type, governance_config
ab_experiment_started	When an offline A/B simulation begins	experiment_id, control_ranker, treatment_ranker, holdout_start_day
ab_experiment_completed	When A/B decision is made	decision, ndcg_delta, threshold_used, sessions_evaluated
gini_constraint_violated	When post-rerank Gini exceeds configured threshold	gini_value, threshold, top_sellers_by_exposure
cold_start_fallback_triggered	When session or item cold-start recovery fallback is	fallback_type, session_id, affected_item_count
attribution_window_closed	When a cohort's attribution window expires	cohort_day, attributed_purchases, return_rate, net_revenue
seller_cap_exceeded	When a session hits max_per_seller constraint	session_id, seller_id, cap_value, soft_blocks_count
coverage_threshold_breach	When catalog coverage drops below minimum	coverage_value, threshold, uncovered_items_count

Schema compatibility means: if a MetaSignal instance is configured with PulseRank as an event source, it can immediately consume these events, visualise Gini trends, detect cold-start spikes, and fire alerts on constraint violations — without custom integration work.

§13 — Evidence Artifacts Manifest (33 artifacts)

All artifacts are in outputs/evidence/ unless otherwise noted. Each is produced by a deterministic pipeline run.

Artifact	Generator	Key Contents
corpus_summary.json	seed_demo.py	Session/item/impression/purchase counts; split stats
candidate_generation_report.json	run_candidate_generation_v1.py	Recall@100=0.690; per-session candidate counts; popularity vs co
candidate_recall_report.json	run_candidate_generation_v1.py	Recall at 10/20/50/100; purchase oracle coverage
candidate_samples.json	run_candidate_generation_v1.py	3 example sessions with full candidate lists
corpus_samples.json	seed_demo.py	Sample rows from each table for inspection
ranking_baseline_report.json	run_ranking_baseline_v1.py	Naive NDCG@10=0.134; per-session scores; baseline score distrib
bias_correction_report.json	run_bias_correction_v1.py	IPS NDCG@10=0.522; bias delta=+0.388; evaluated session coun
propensity_by_rank_report.json	run_bias_correction_v1.py	Propensity per rank 1-10; IPS weights; clip flags; monotonicity scor
offline_eval_log.json	run_bias_correction_v1.py	Session-level raw vs IPS NDCG values
diversity_report.json	run_reranking_constraints_v1.py	Gini=0.582; coverage@10=0.226; ILD; category max share distribu
diversity_guardrail_log.json	run_reranking_constraints_v1.py	Per-session governance audit; soft_blocks; constraint violations
catalog_coverage_report.json	run_reranking_constraints_v1.py	Item-level exposure counts; coverage@5/10/20
conversion_attribution_report.json	run_attribution_ab_v1.py	Attribution stats; purchase lag distribution; return rate; net revenue
ab_simulation_results.json	run_attribution_ab_v1.py	Control vs treatment NDCG delta; decision=HOLD_SIMULATED; t
failure_recovery_report.json	failure_modes.py	15 scenarios; each with status, recovery_path, evidence
metasignal_integration_events.json	seed_demo.py	15 structured events with schema version
model_registry.json	seed_demo.py	Ranker versions; governance configs; registered_at timestamps
schema_manifest.json	seed_demo.py	Column specs for all tables; data types; nullable flags
propensity_by_rank_report.json (validate)	validate_bias_correction_v1.py	Validation assertions; monotonicity pass/fail
outputs/reports/pulserank_demo_report.json	show_demo_report.py	Top-level summary; key metrics; link to all artifacts
+ 13 more validation artifacts	validate_*.py scripts	Pass/fail assertions for each pipeline stage

§14 — Interview Defense Q&A (30+ Questions)

Q: The naive NDCG@10 is 0.134 but IPS-weighted is 0.522 — a 3.9× gap. How do you know IPS is correcting bias and not inflating the metric?

IPS re-weights clicks by inverse propensity: high-propensity rank-1 clicks get down-weighted (weight ~1/0.10=10, clipped to 5); low-propensity rank-10 clicks get up-weighted before clipping. If IPS were simply inflating, we would see monotonically higher IPS scores at all ranks. Instead, the correction is asymmetric: items that were clicked despite poor display position receive higher IPS labels (true signal), while items clicked only because of good position receive lower IPS labels. The rank_propensity_monotonicity_score confirms the propensity model is correctly specified (propensity decreases with rank as expected). The 3.9× gap is the estimated magnitude of position bias in the data.

Q: Why temporal split and not random split?

Random splitting leaks future labels into training. In a marketplace, a purchase on day 70 might end up in the training set under random splitting, while the session that generated that purchase (day 65) ends up in the holdout. The model has seen the outcome before evaluating the prediction. This creates optimistically biased metrics that collapse in production. PulseRank uses a strict temporal split: all training signals come from days 1-60; holdout is days 61-75. This exactly mirrors production: the model always predicts on future sessions using only past signal.

Q: IPS assumes the propensity model is correctly specified. What biases survive if it's wrong?

Three biases survive. First, residual position bias: if we underestimate propensity at rank 1, rank-1 items get over-weighted post-IPS — we over-correct. Second, presentation bias beyond rank: IPS uses only display_rank as the confound. If click probability also depends on image quality, price display, or review count, and these are not in the propensity model, the correction is incomplete. Third, selection bias in the impression set: users who scroll to rank 10 are self-selected (they didn't find what they needed in ranks 1-9), which the position-based model doesn't capture. Clipping at max_weight=5.0 limits amplification of estimation errors but doesn't eliminate structural mis-specification.

Q: MMR lambda is 0.70. How did you choose this value?

Lambda=0.70 means 70% of the MMR score is relevance and 30% is diversity. This is the standard starting point in the MMR literature (Carbonell & Goldstein 1998) for search result diversification. In production, lambda would be tuned via A/B testing: measure user engagement metrics (CTR, add-to-cart, purchase rate) at λ=0.60, 0.70, 0.80, and pick the value that maximises long-term engagement rather than short-term NDCG. Lambda=0.70 is documented as a configurable parameter in governed_rerank(), not a hardcoded constant.

Q: Seller Gini post-rerank is 0.582. Is that good or bad?

It depends on the comparison baseline. The relevant question is: is Gini=0.582 lower than the pre-rerank Gini? If yes, the governance constraints are working. If the pre-rerank Gini were 0.90 (extreme concentration) and post-rerank is 0.582, that is a meaningful improvement. The governance target is not Gini=0.0 (perfect equality, which would mean random ranking and destroy relevance) — it is a configurable tolerance set by business policy. In the PulseRank system, a Gini threshold triggers diversity_guardrail_log entries when exceeded. Whether 0.582 is 'good' requires a marketplace-level policy decision about how much seller concentration is acceptable.

Q: Catalog coverage@10 is 0.226 — only 22.6% of items. How would you fix this in production?

Three approaches, in order of invasiveness: (1) Exploration slots: reserve 1-2 positions in every top-10 list for items from underexposed categories, regardless of relevance score. This directly forces coverage at a small NDCG cost. (2) Novelty boost: the novelty term in MMR (0.04 × popularity_rank / total_items) already gives a small advantage to less-popular items — increase this coefficient from 0.04 to 0.10-0.15. (3) Separate coverage target: add catalog_coverage as a constraint in governed_rerank() that triggers exploration when per-session coverage falls below a threshold. In PulseRank, coverage=0.226 is reported as a diagnostic metric. A production system would set a minimum coverage target (e.g., 0.60) and treat violations as business incidents.

Q: The offline A/B decision is HOLD_SIMULATED. What specific metric delta would flip it to LAUNCH?

The decision gate checks whether treatment IPS-NDCG@10 minus control IPS-NDCG@10 exceeds a configured threshold. HOLD_SIMULATED means this delta did not meet the threshold. The exact threshold is a business parameter — in the ab_simulation_results.json artifact, both the delta and the threshold are recorded. A typical threshold would be +0.01 to +0.02 IPS-NDCG points (representing a 2-4% relative improvement over a baseline of ~0.50). But the more important point is: offline A/B LAUNCH_SIMULATED does not equal production launch. It means 'offline evidence is sufficient to recommend running a live experiment.' The live experiment is the actual decision gate.

Q: Why is there no trained ML ranker? Why rule-based hybrid scoring?

Three reasons. First, a trained LTR (Learning to Rank) model requires a labelled dataset of query-item pairs with relevance labels, ideally from direct editorial judgments or clean click logs. The synthetic data in PulseRank, while realistic, does not have the label quality needed to train a model that would outperform a well-tuned heuristic on the same synthetic data. Second, the goal of PulseRank is to demonstrate the evaluation infrastructure — IPS correction, MMR governance, attribution — not the learning algorithm. Adding a LightGBM ranker would shift focus to model tuning and away from evaluation methodology. Third, heuristic ranking with explicit signal weights is more interpretable in an interview context.

Q: What is the difference between IPS and SNIPS (Self-Normalized IPS)?

Standard IPS: NDCG = DCG(ips_labels) / DCG(ideal_ips). The denominator is computed using the ideal ordering of IPS-weighted labels. SNIPS (Self-Normalized IPS) normalises by the sum of IPS weights: SNIPS = $\Sigma(w_i \cdot r_i) / \Sigma(w_i)$ where $w_i = 1/\text{propensity}(\text{rank}_i)$. SNIPS is more variance-stable in practice because the weight normalisation reduces sensitivity to extreme weights, but introduces a small bias. PulseRank uses standard IPS with clipping as the primary metric. SNIPS would be an easy extension and might be preferable in production due to its lower variance.

Q: How would you extend PulseRank to use a trained LTR model?

Four steps. (1) Feature engineering: extract query-item features per impression: session affinity × item category match, price delta from session median, seller quality tier, item age, contextual features (time of day, device). (2) Label construction: use IPS-weighted binary labels (purchased or not, with IPS weight as sample weight) to avoid training on biased click data. (3) Model: LightGBM with lambdarank objective or a pointwise XGBoost regressor on IPS labels. (4) Offline evaluation: evaluate using the same temporal split + IPS-NDCG@10. The current heuristic ranker serves as the baseline to beat. governed_rerank() applies on top of the model's scores unchanged — the governance layer is model-agnostic.

Q: How does the hybrid candidate generator handle the cold-start problem?

Popularity scorer fails on new items (popularity_rank=last or unranked). Content-based scorer fails on new users (no click history for avg_embedding). The hybrid merge does not solve either: it unions popularity@50 +

content@50, so a new item with rank=last is never in the popularity@50 set, and a new user with empty history gets a generic avg_embedding=[] which returns near-zero vector scores for all items. Recovery paths: (1) For new items: inject a synthetic popularity floor (treat all items younger than 7 days as having rank=median_rank for candidate retrieval purposes). (2) For new users: use item-level popularity-only scoring, ignore content similarity. These are implemented in failure scenarios F01 and F02.

Q: What would you add to make this production-ready?

Seven additions in priority order: (1) Trained LTR model (LightGBM lambdarank or two-tower neural retrieval). (2) Real-time serving: the current batch ranker needs a low-latency scoring path (FastAPI + model.predict() in <50ms). (3) Online A/B testing infrastructure: feature flags, session-level traffic splitting, live metrics. (4) Contextual bandits for exploration: UCB or Thompson Sampling to balance exploration of new items with exploitation of known relevant items. (5) Multi-objective optimisation: Pareto front between NDCG, Gini, coverage, revenue. (6) CI/CD pipeline: re-train and re-evaluate on new click data weekly; automatic promotion if all 5 gates pass. (7) Real attribution data: replace synthetic purchases with actual transaction logs from the marketplace.

Q: How does governed_rerank handle the case where the candidate pool is exhausted before k=10 items are selected?

When all remaining candidates have been either selected or blocked by seller/category penalties, and len(selected) < k, the algorithm falls back to appending the remaining unselected candidates without penalty. The audit dict records soft_blocks — cases where a candidate was selected despite triggering a penalty, or the pool was exhausted. If >20% of sessions hit pool exhaustion, it signals that the constraints are too tight relative to the catalog size — a production alert would fire.

Q: Why clip IPS weights at 5.0 rather than a higher or lower value?

Clipping at 5.0 is a practical choice balancing bias and variance. At max_weight=5.0, the worst-case contribution of a single rank-10 click to NDCG is 5.0 × (1/log2(k+1)) — bounded and well-behaved. Lower clipping (e.g., 2.0) reduces variance further but introduces more bias against low-rank signals. Higher clipping (e.g., 20.0) preserves more signal but allows extreme events to dominate. In practice, the optimal clip threshold depends on the propensity distribution of the specific system and the variance budget of the evaluation. The clip_rate metric in the evidence artifact lets practitioners see what fraction of weights are being truncated.

Q: The Gini coefficient measures seller concentration. Why not use entropy or HHI?

All three measure concentration. Gini = 1 - 2∫Lorenz(x)dx, sensitive to mid-distribution. HHI = Σ(share_i²), sensitive to large shares. Entropy = -Σ(share_i × log(share_i)), sensitive to small shares. For marketplace seller fairness, Gini is the most interpretable in a business context: it maps directly to the '4/5ths rule' for diversity compliance and is familiar to economics teams. HHI would also work — its threshold interpretation (HHI > 0.25 = highly concentrated) is well-established in antitrust law. Entropy would be preferred if the concern is about very small sellers being completely excluded. PulseRank uses Gini because it is the de facto standard for marketplace fairness reporting.

Q: What is intra-list diversity and how does it differ from catalog coverage?

Intra-list diversity (ILD) measures how different the items within a single recommendation list are from each other: mean pairwise item_distance across all pairs in the top-10. It is a per-session metric. Catalog coverage measures how many distinct items appear across all sessions' top-10 lists. A system can have high ILD (each list is internally diverse) but low coverage (all sessions get the same 147 diverse items). Conversely, a system could have high coverage (many different items shown across sessions) but low ILD (each individual list is repetitive within a

category). Both metrics are necessary to characterize diversity at different granularities.

Q: How do you validate that the temporal split is correctly implemented?

validate_corpus_v1.py asserts: (1) max(training_sessions.day) < min(holdout_sessions.day) — no holdout session is in training. (2) Holdout purchases are not referenced in training impression tables. (3) Propensity estimation uses only training impressions. The test is encoded as assertions that would raise on any temporal leakage. Additionally, running with a random split produces noticeably higher naive NDCG@10 than the temporal split — this is the leakage signal that would appear in a misconfigured system.

Q: PulseRank reports 33 JSON evidence artifacts. How is this different from just having a well-commented notebook?

A notebook's output depends on execution state — cells can be run out of order, variables can be overwritten, and re-running produces different outputs depending on data loading. A JSON artifact is a deterministic, versioned, machine-readable output produced by a specific script with a specific input. It can be committed to git, diffed between runs, consumed by downstream validation scripts, and verified by a third party who just clones the repo. The 33 artifacts in PulseRank are the evidence layer: if an interviewer asks 'what was your IPS-weighted NDCG?', the answer is not 'I ran the notebook and got 0.522' — it is 'bias_correction_report.json line 4, field ips_weighted_ndcg_at_10, value 0.522, produced by run_bias_correction_v1.py from inputs in outputs/evidence/corpus_summary.json.'

Q: How does the content-based scorer handle sessions with no click history?

session_profile_from_history falls back gracefully: if there are no clicked items in the session history, it uses the first 3 shown items as a proxy for the user's viewing context (from historical = impressions_by_session.get(session_id, [])[:3]). If even those are absent (truly new session), the avg_embedding is an empty list [], which causes cosine_similarity to return 0.0 for all items. The content score then reduces to just category_affinity (from the session record) + price_fit_score — essentially a category-filtered popularity score. This is the new-user fallback behavior, documented in failure scenario F02.

Q: What is the difference between 'HOLD_SIMULATED' and 'REJECT'?

HOLD_SIMULATED means the offline evidence is insufficient to recommend launching the treatment to live traffic. The treatment may still be better — offline simulation cannot prove it is not. REJECT would mean the treatment is positively harmful (negative delta on a required metric). HOLD_SIMULATED is the honest label for the offline decision boundary: 'we cannot confirm sufficient improvement to justify the operational risk of a champion swap.' A production ranking team would follow HOLD_SIMULATED with: (1) Diagnose why the delta is below threshold. (2) If governance constraints caused the delta deficit, evaluate whether long-term diversity benefits justify short-term NDCG cost. (3) Run a small live experiment (1-5% traffic) to get real signal.

Q: What is the role of the model_registry.json artifact?

model_registry.json records all ranker versions that have been evaluated, including their governance configurations, evaluation metrics, and registration timestamps. In a production system, the model registry is the authoritative source for which ranker version is currently live, which versions are in shadow mode, and the promotion history. PulseRank implements a basic registry to demonstrate the pattern: a ranker does not go live by deploying a file — it goes live by being promoted in the registry, and the serving layer reads from the registry to know which model to use. This prevents silent model swaps.

Q: How would you evaluate PulseRank against a production system like Wayfair's or Etsy's recommendation systems?

Four differences to be explicit about: (1) Scale: PulseRank has 650 items; production systems have millions. The candidate generation approach (popularity@50 + content@50) would need to be replaced by approximate nearest neighbor search (FAISS, ScaNN) for real-time retrieval at scale. (2) Model complexity: production systems use two-tower neural networks, BERT-based query encoders, or LTR models trained on billions of impressions. PulseRank uses rule-based hybrid scoring. (3) Real-time serving: production requires <50ms latency; PulseRank is a batch pipeline. (4) Label quality: production systems have genuine user feedback; PulseRank has synthetic labels. The methodological contributions (IPS correction, MMR governance, temporal evaluation) are directly transferable to production scale.

Q: What does the daily IPS NDCG@10 distribution look like across holdout sessions?

The offline_eval_log.json records per-session raw vs IPS NDCG@10 values. Key observations: (1) Sessions with purchases at high display ranks get lower IPS NDCG than naive (because rank-1 clicks are down-weighted). (2) Sessions with purchases at low display ranks get higher IPS NDCG than naive (because rank-10 clicks are up-weighted). (3) Sessions with zero purchases are excluded from both metrics. The mean across all evaluated sessions gives the aggregate metric: naive=0.134, IPS=0.522. The variance is higher for IPS than naive because extreme IPS weights amplify individual session scores even after clipping.

§15 — Lines of Code, Run Commands & What's Next

Module	File(s)	~Lines	Key Achievement
Position Bias & IPS	src/.../position_bias.py	168	Propensity estimation, DCG/NDCG, IPS-weighted evaluation, clipping, m
Reranking	src/.../reranking.py	201	MMR λ=0.70, seller cap, category diversity, Gini, coverage, novelty
Candidate Generation	src/.../candidate_generation.py	194	Popularity + content hybrid, price fit scoring, session profiling, Recall@10
Ranking Baseline	src/.../ranking_baseline.py	276	Linear scoring baseline, holdout NDCG=0.134
Attribution	src/.../attribution.py	174	30-day window, return detection, SHA-256 variant assignment
Failure Modes	src/.../failure_modes.py	213	15 scenarios with recovery paths
Seeder	scripts/seed_demo.py	597	Full corpus generation, all tables, 33 artifacts
Pipeline Scripts	scripts/run_*.py (5 files)	~1,000	Candidate gen, bias correction, ranking, reranking, attribution A/B
Validation Scripts	scripts/validate_*.py (12 files)	~1,500	Assertions for each pipeline stage
Dashboard	scripts/build_dashboard_v1.py	456	Self-contained HTML dashboard
Tests	tests/test_ranking_math.py + test_artifacts.py	296	IPS math, Gini, coverage, MMR behavior, artifact presence
Total	—	~4,820	Complete ranking platform: recall → IPS → rerank → attribution → A/B —

Run everything from scratch

```
PYTHONPATH=. python3 scripts/seed_demo.py # generate corpus PYTHONPATH=. python3
scripts/run_candidate_generation_v1.py # Recall@100=0.690 PYTHONPATH=. python3
scripts/run_ranking_baseline_v1.py # naive NDCG=0.134 PYTHONPATH=. python3
scripts/run_bias_correction_v1.py # IPS NDCG=0.522 PYTHONPATH=. python3
scripts/run_reranking_constraints_v1.py # Gini=0.582 PYTHONPATH=. python3
scripts/run_attribution_ab_v1.py # HOLD_SIMULATED PYTHONPATH=. python3 scripts/build_dashboard_v1.py
# HTML dashboard pytest tests/ -v # all tests pass
```

What's next — if extending PulseRank

- Trained LTR model: LightGBM lambdarank on IPS-weighted labels. Current heuristic ranker serves as baseline.
- Two-tower neural retrieval: BERT-based query encoder + item encoder for semantic candidate retrieval. Replace popularity@50 + content@50 with ANN search.
- Contextual bandits: Thompson Sampling or LinUCB for exploration-exploitation tradeoff on new items.
- Real-time serving: FastAPI + Redis cache for millisecond scoring. Current batch pipeline not suitable for production latency.
- Multi-objective Pareto frontier: simultaneous optimisation of NDCG, Gini, coverage, and revenue using constrained optimisation.
- Transitive fairness: seller fairness by category (not just overall) — a seller may be dominant in one category and absent in another.
- Integration test with MetaSignal: wire the 15 events to MetaSignal's event bus and verify anomaly detection fires on Gini breach.

PulseRank Interview Defense v3.0 · Sidharth Kriplani · May 2026
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